

Shared Moments, Different Meanings: Media Events, Framing, and Audience Interpretation in the Construction of Collective Identity

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Introduction

In the contemporary media environment, large media performances and events are often regarded as an important moment that can connect people simultaneously. When tens of thousands of viewers watch the same program at the same time, this situation seems to easily give people a feeling that “everyone is experiencing the same thing together”. Therefore, such media events are often understood as special moments that can promote collective identity and enhance social cohesion. But if we take a close look at the reactions of different audiences, we will find that this claim of “shared experience” is actually not that accurate. Even if people are watching the same event, their understanding, emotions and the final opinions they form may vary greatly, and sometimes even conflict with each other. It is precisely under such circumstances that a question has become increasingly worthy of attention: How do large media events & performances shape collective identity differently for different audiences?

When we look at this issue in combination with existing research, we can find that the authors involved in these studies have actually provided inconsistent explanations for the relationship between media events and audiences from different perspectives. On the one hand, some scholars emphasize the “commonality” created by media events. For instance, some scholars have pointed out that Media events can be understood as “events can be characterised as temporally bound intensifications of social action and related moments of

heightened sociality”(Sumiala, 2022, p. 345), which indicates that they strengthen the connection among audiences by concentrating social attention at specific times. In this case, when audiences watch the same event at the same time, media events seem to be able to promote the formation of a certain collective identity.

On the other hand, research on how media influence people’s understanding offers a different explanation. The framework theory holds that media do not simply present reality but shape the audience’s understanding by selecting and emphasizing specific information. As Entman pointed out: “Framing essentially involves selection and salience. To frame is to select some aspects of a perceived reality and make them more salient in a communicating text, in such a way as to promote a particular problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation, and/or treatment recommendation” (Entman, 1993, p. 52). This means that the content received by the audience has already been organized and guided during the presentation process, and this organization itself may lead to different understanding results. When these viewpoints are put together, on the one hand, media events seem to be able to create a shared viewing moment; On the other hand, the choices and emphasis made by the media during the presentation process make it difficult for this “sharing” to be transformed into a truly consistent meaning. This difference is precisely the key to understanding the relationship between media events and collective identity.

Based on the above discussion, the core focus of this article is: When audiences watch the same media performance, how does it shape different forms of collective identity among different audiences? Regarding this issue, this article holds that media events do not directly generate a unified collective identity, but rather create a “shared moment” in which different meanings coexist and are constantly constructed. Specifically, the media selects and organizes events through frameworks, providing the audience with a direction for understanding. However, this understanding is not fixed but can change during the

interpretation process by different audiences. Therefore, collective identity is not an automatic result of media events themselves, but gradually forms in the interaction between media structure and audience interpretation. Based on this train of thought, this article will first discuss the basic characteristics of media events, then analyze how the framework affects the construction of meaning, subsequently explore the role of the audience in the interpretation process, and finally re-understand the relationship between media events and collective identity by integrating these perspectives.

Media Events and the Illusion of Shared Experience

Media Events as Shared Experience

Before analyzing how media events affect collective identity, it is necessary to first understand the basic meaning of “media events” in communication studies. Unlike daily news dissemination, media events are usually regarded as a form of communication with special significance. They can break the original information rhythm in a short time and focus the attention of a large number of viewers on the same event. As Sumiala pointed out, Media event “are powerful enough to interrupt the everyday flow of news and journalism engage the audience with society’s core values, and invite them to participate in the event” (Sumiala, 2022, p. 347). This suggests that media events are not merely the presentation of information, but a communication process that can actively attract and guide the audience to participate, and to a certain extent, they influence the way people engage in public life. Meanwhile, this large-scale synchronous dissemination also provides conditions for the formation of “shared experiences”. Cui et al. pointed out that: “when millions of geographically dispersed viewers are synchronized in time, media are offering them a social experience oriented toward a shared identity.” (Cui et al., 2016, p. 482). In other words, even if the audience is geographically dispersed, they may still develop a certain sense of connection during the viewing process, thereby forming a collective experience in a short

period of time. For instance, when the World Cup final kicks off, people from different regions of the world will go to watch the game. At this point, regardless of whether they are from the countries of these two teams or not, they all share a common identity as fans. This identity makes them realize that fans all over the world are watching the game with them, thus creating a sense of connection. However, merely understanding media events from the perspective of “synchronous viewing” remains limited, as there is still uncertainty as to whether this shared experience can truly translate into a stable collective identity.

Ritual and Emotional Engagement

While emphasizing that media events can focus the audience’s attention, some studies also understand them as a form of communication with a ritualistic nature. Unlike daily news, media events are often endowed with symbolic meanings, enabling the audience not only to receive information but also to participate in a collective activity with social and cultural significance. As Sonnevend pointed out, Media events are regarded as “high holidays of mass communication in social life” (Sonnevend, 2018, p. 110). At these moments, daily life is temporarily interrupted and the audience is guided to focus on those public events of special significance. For instance, on a certain day, a parade took place. This kind of parade made some people in the same situation feel the energy. This ritualistic nature is not only reflected in the concentration of attention but also in the participation at the emotional level. Cui et al. pointed out that “viewers experienced emotional arousal when they watched the media event” (Cui et al., 2016, p. 481). This indicates that the influence of media events is not limited to information transmission, but also enhances the audience’s sense of participation by evoking emotions, making this viewing experience have stronger social significance. However, this connection formed based on rituals and emotions does not mean that all viewers will understand events in the same way. Even when emotions are reinforced, this sense of collectivism can still be short-lived and unstable.

Power and Instability of Media Events

Although media events strengthen the connection among audiences in a short period of time through shared experiences and ritualistic communication, this process does not occur naturally and steadily. Some scholars point out that media events are often constructed in specific social and political contexts, and their significance is influenced by the power structure. As Yu pointed out: “the party-state can effectively use media events to pull social, cultural and political resources and forces together in the name of national rejuvenation.” (Yu, 2009, p. 2). This indicates that media events not only reflect reality but also guide the audience’s understanding by selecting and organizing information, thereby promoting specific values or identifications. For instance, some large-scale celebrations or political ceremonies organized by the state are usually presented as moments of “national unity”, making the audience feel that they belong to a common national identity. However, this sense of unity does not arise naturally but is influenced by the way media is presented. Different audiences may still have different understandings based on their own backgrounds. Even if the media attempts to strengthen the unified collective identity in this way, the effect is not always stable. Just as Cui said: “collective emotional effervescence among a large audience is evoked and their social identity reinforced” (Cui et al., 2016, p. 482). Although media events can evoke collective emotions, these emotions do not necessarily translate into unanimous understanding or long-term identification. Overall, viewers may share emotional experiences during the viewing process, but there are still differences in their understanding of events. Therefore, the “shared experience” created by media events is not equivalent to “shared meaning”.

Framing and the Construction of Meaning

Framing as the Selection of Meaning

When the shared experience in media events does not necessarily lead to a stable

collective identity, this paper holds that it is necessary to analyze how meaning is constructed. One of the key concepts is “framing”. As Entman pointed out, framing refers to the selection and highlighting of certain aspects of reality, thereby influencing people’s understanding and judgment of events. He noted: “To frame is to select some aspects of a perceived reality and make them more salient in a communicating text” (Entman, 1993, p. 52). This indicates that the media do not simply present or completely transport events to the public, but rather organize information during the presentation process to make certain explanations more acceptable to the audience. Looking further, Scheufele believes that framing is not a single-level process but a complex one involving media production and audience interpretation. He pointed out that framing “is a continuous process” that links media, audiences, and individual interpretation (Scheufele, 1999, p. 105). Therefore, even if the audience is confronted with the same media event, their understanding may be influenced by different frameworks from the very beginning, as they might receive different information from different media, thus creating differences. This suggests that audience perception is shaped by what the media chooses to present, rather than reflecting reality in a neutral or complete way.

Framing and the Formation of Identity

At the same time, framing not only affects how people understand events but also further influences how they form identification. Entman pointed out that the framing works to “define problems” not only emphasizes certain information but also guides the audience’s judgment by explaining the problems, attributing the causes, and providing evaluations. diagnose causes... make moral judgments... and suggest remedies” (Entman, 1993, p. 52). This way of organizing meaning will, to a certain extent, inevitably affect the audience’s understanding of social reality and thus their perception of their own position. Meanwhile, Gautam's research also indicates that when media present cultural or social issues, they

reinforce certain identity categories through specific frameworks, making it easier for viewers to understand themselves and others from a certain perspective. For example, the media reproduced “shapes how identities are constructed and understood” (Gautam, 2019, p. 3). That is to say, the media is not merely describing events but guiding the audience to associate these events with specific identities through a framework. However, this kind of identification formed through the framework does not mean that all viewers will accept the same interpretation, because different individuals may still understand these constructed meanings in different ways.

Framing as a Dynamic and Unstable Process

Although framing plays a significant role in shaping meaning, it does not entirely determine the audience’s understanding. Scheufele pointed out that framing is not a one-way influence but a dynamic process that incorporates feedback mechanisms. He emphasized this process as “involves frame building, frame setting, and individual-level effects”(Scheufele, 1999, p. 115). This indicates that the audience is not completely passive when receiving information, but is constantly interpreting and adjusting it. Meanwhile, the research of Yoo and Buzinde also indicates that different audiences will have different understandings of the same content based on their own cultural backgrounds. They pointed out that tourists and audiences would “negotiate meanings based on their own cultural frameworks” (Yoo & Buzinde, 2012, p. 521). This means that even if the media attempts to guide a unified understanding through a specific framework, differences may still arise among the audience. Therefore, the framework does not fix the meaning but merely provides a path of interpretation. It is precisely because of this uncertainty that focusing on the audience themselves is the key, thereby understanding how they interpret the same media event differently in specific situations.

Audience Agency and the Diversity of Interpretation

Audience Agency in Meaning Construction

The previous part pointed out that the media framework cannot completely determine meaning, which means that when the audience understands media events, they are not passive recipients but actively participate in the process of meaning construction. As Ytre-Arne and Das pointed out, the audience has a certain degree of activity in the communication process. They defined this ability as “the power potentials of people, as audiences or users, in processes of communication” (Ytre-Arne & Das, 2021, p. 779.) This indicates that when audiences encounter media content, they do not simply accept it but possess the ability to participate and influence it. Meanwhile, Stuart Hall’s encoding/decoding theory further illustrates this point. He pointed out that “there is no necessary correspondence between encoding and decoding” (Hall, 1980, p. 124). Therefore, even if the media attempts to guide a unified understanding through framing, viewers may still interpret the information differently based on their own experiences, thus making the meaning generated by media events uncertain.

Interpretation and Social Difference

So the background differences among the audience will further magnify this disparity in understanding. The cultural experience, social class and existing cognition of different individuals will all influence how they interpret the same media event. As Hall pointed out, there may be an unequal relationship between encoding and decoding. That is “a lack of equivalence between the two sides in the communicative exchange” (Hall, 1980, p. 121), which implies that the audience’s understanding is not necessarily in line with the media’s intention. Meanwhile, the research of Yoo and Buzinde also indicates that meaning is not determined by the text itself. They pointed out that the media content “has no inherent meaning. Rather, meaning is constructed by viewers as they watch, process and interact with the text” (Yoo & Buzinde, 2012, p. 223). Therefore, even if the audience is confronted with

the same media event, they may still form different understandings based on different social and cultural backgrounds. In other words, the framework provided by the media is merely a starting point, while meaning is constantly constructed through the participation of the audience.

Shared Experience without Shared Meaning

Therefore, the activity of the audience makes it impossible for the “shared experience” in media events to be simply transformed into “shared meaning”. Although media events can create a sense of shared participation through ritualistic and emotional mobilization, this commonality itself is not stable. As Cui et al. pointed out, media events can evoke the collective emotions of the audience and strengthen identification. They believe that “collective emotional effervescence among a large audience is evoked and their social identity reinforced” (Cui et al., 2016, p. 482), but this kind of identification does not mean that all audiences will form the same understanding. Meanwhile, Ytre-Arne and Das also emphasize the active role of the audience in the communication process. They pointed out that “it refers to the power potentials of people, as audiences or users, in processes of communication” (Ytre-Arne & Das, 2021, p. 779). Therefore, even if media events create a common viewing moment on the surface, this sharing is more of a unity in context rather than a consistency in meaning. It is precisely at this point that “shared experience” is not equivalent to “shared meaning”.

Media Power and Audience Interpretation

The Interaction between Framing and Interpretation

After a comprehensive analysis of the previous text, it can be found that media events cannot simply and stably shape collective identity through “shared experiences”. Although media events can capture the audience's attention in a short period of time, their significance always depends on how the media presents them. As Entman pointed out, framing involves

“selecting some aspects of a perceived reality and making them more salient” (Entman, 1993, p. 52) This indicates that the media organizes meaning by selecting and emphasizing specific information during the communication process. However, this meaning will not be fully accepted by the audience. As Stuart Hall emphasized, “there is no necessary correspondence between encoding and decoding” (Hall, 1980, p. 124), This means that the audience is independent in the process of interpretation. Therefore, the meaning of media events is not the result of one-way transmission, but is constantly formed in the interaction between framing and audience interpretation.

Media Power versus Audience Agency

Also, this interactive relationship reflects the tension between media power and audience initiative. On the one hand, media organizations can guide the audience's understanding by organizing and controlling the content they disseminate. For instance, Yu pointed out that media events are often used to integrate social resources and reinforce specific narratives. She pointed out that “the party-state can effectively use media events to pull social, cultural and political resources and forces together in the name of national rejuvenation” (Yu, 2009, p. 36). On the other hand, the audience will not fully accept this kind of control but will reconstruct it during the interpretation process. As Ytre-Arne and Das pointed out, the audience has “the power potentials of people, as audiences or users, in processes of communication” (Ytre-Arne & Das, 2021, p. 779.) This indicates that the audience is not only the recipient of information but also the participant of meaning, and the audience always has an independent consciousness. Therefore, although media power can influence the direction of meaning, it cannot completely determine the ultimate form of meaning.

Collective Identity as a Negotiated Process

Overall, collective identity is not a direct result of media events, but a dynamic and

constantly changing process. As Scheufele pointed out, framing is not accomplished in one go but is a continuous development process. He emphasized this process as “involves frame building, frame setting, and individual-level effects” (Scheufele, 1999, p. 115) This indicates that meaning is constantly being constructed on multiple levels. Meanwhile, Cui et al. also pointed out that media events can evoke the collective emotions of the audience. They believe that “collective emotional effervescence among a large audience is evoked and their social identity reinforced” (Cui et al., 2016, p. 482), but this kind of identification does not mean that the audience will form a unanimous understanding. Therefore, although media events can create a shared viewing moment, this “shared experience” is more of a superficial unity rather than a consistency in meaning. In other words, shared moment is not equivalent to shared meaning, and collective identity is the result of continuous negotiation between the media structure and the audience's interpretation.

Conclusion

Although large-scale media events can attract the attention of a large number of viewers and create a strong sense of “co-participation”, this article shows that such shared moments do not necessarily mean shared significance. The seemingly uniform experience on the surface is actually influenced by the audience's background, existing cognition and differences in the framework of interpretation. Even if people watch the same event at the same time, they may not reach the same understanding. This indicates that “shared experience” is more of a synchronization in time rather than a consistency in cognition.

Furthermore, framing plays a significant role in guiding the audience to understand media events, but this influence is limited. The media can, to a certain extent, influence the direction of interpretation by selecting and highlighting certain information. However, the audience will not passively accept these frameworks. Instead, they will screen, adjust and

even question the information based on their own social position and experience. Therefore, the framework does not fix the meaning but merely provides a possible path of interpretation.

So the initiative of the audience further complicates the relationship between media events and collective identity. Meaning is not transmitted linearly but is constructed in the continuous process of interpretation. Due to the differences among audiences in cultural background, social context and personal experience, the same media event often leads to multiple or even conflicting understandings. Therefore, a shared viewing moment does not guarantee the formation of a unified cognition.

Overall, these analyses indicate that collective identity is not a direct outcome of media events, but rather a dynamic process formed through continuous negotiation between media structure and audience interpretation. Media events offer a common context, but the meanings generated within this context are diverse, unstable and constantly changing. In this sense, the seemingly unified media experience is often merely a kind of “superficial unity” resulting from synchronized attention, rather than a true consensus.

This conclusion also raises a deeper question: In the contemporary media society, if shared media experiences cannot bring about shared meanings, is it still possible for a “unified collective identity” to exist? Perhaps, rather than creating consensus, the media provides a space where different interpretations coexist and even compete with each other. Future research can further explore how these differences are influenced by political, cultural and technological factors, and how they shape an individual's understanding of their position within a group.

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